The Tasman Glacier

New Zealand's largest glacier, with a skiing arena at its top and a silty lake at its foot

The Tasman Glacier flows down a long valley to the east of New Zealand's highest mountain, Aoraki, or Mount Cook, originating in a large ice accumulation area at an altitude of 9,200 ft (2,800 m). In total, it is 15 miles (24 km) long.

Ski runs, crevasses, and lakes

The upper part of the glacier is smooth and supplies one of the world's longest ski runs, about 7 miles (11 km) in length. Farther down, it breaks up into a maze of crevasses and ice tunnels. The lower third is covered in a thick layer of rock debris—the result of ice melting. At the foot of the glacier is a large meltwater lake that has enlarged considerably in recent decades. It is up to 820 ft (250 m) deep and is gray colored due to suspended silt. The lake has a steady temperature close to freezing because icebergs are continually discharged into it from the glacier's terminus.

In 2011, millions of **tons of ice** fell from the **glacier** into its **lake** after an **earthquake**

△ BRAIDED FLOW
An intricate braided river (a network of branching channels with intervening sand and gravel bars) carries water away from the melting glacier.

FEATURES OF A RETREATING GLACIER

A retreating glacier such as the Tasman leaves behind some characteristic landscape features below its terminus (or snout). These may include drumlins (elongated hills lined up in the direction of retreat), kettle lakes (water-filled depressions left behind when partially buried ice blocks melt), and eskers (long, winding ridges of sand and gravel).